

# THE FORGOTTEN SEVEN



MAHAD A. BAJWA

# THE FORGOTTEN SEVEN

*Mahad A. Bajwa*

The Forgotten Seven

Copyright © 2026 Mahad A. Bajwa. All rights reserved.

Draft edition, built September 25, 2026.

# CONTENTS

|                                       |    |
|---------------------------------------|----|
| Chapter One: The Bindery . . . . .    | 5  |
| Chapter Two: The Low Office . . . . . | 20 |

## CHAPTER ONE

# THE BINDERY

The radio in the kitchen was already going when Owen came down the stairs.

“...and the new Light Grandmaster was back at Harbor Arena last night, folks, for her very first exhibition. Sixteen years old and five months on the job, and I don’t mind telling you, when Talia Reyes lit up that arena I had to take my hat off to shade my eyes. And afterward, when we asked her who that one was for, she looked right into the microphone and said, ‘*Cable Street.*’ How about that...”

“Turn it up!” Tess said.

Owen reached over and turned it off.

“Hey!”

“I’m eating.”

His sister glared at him. She was ten, sitting cross-legged on a kitchen chair with her trading cards spread over the table in neat rows, like she was running a bank. The seven Grandmasters had the middle of the table to themselves. The newest card sat right in the center, still shiny, with no bent corners at all. It showed a girl with her dark hair tied back in a high ponytail and her hand raised, light pouring off her fingers. Across the bottom, in gold letters: TALIA REYES, LIGHT GRANDMASTER.

And under that, in blue ink and slightly smudged, in handwriting Owen had been reading off notes passed in class since they were seven: *To Tess, my number one fan. Don’t trade me. —T.*

It had come in the post two months ago, in a stiff Ministry envelope with Tess’s name on the front. There had been nothing in it for Owen. There had never been anything for Owen.

“I’m never trading her,” Tess said, as though he had suggested it. “Not even for Rourke.”

“Nobody asked you to trade her.”

“People ask me *every day*.”

Pop was at the stove with his sleeves rolled up and his work shirt already buttoned for the early shift at the Eastside power station. He snapped his fingers over the burner, and a flame the size of a match flicked to life and caught the gas. It was the same small, tidy flame he’d made every morning of Owen’s life, the same one he fed into the boilers at the station eight hours a day, six days a week. His griamore sat on the windowsill with its cloth cover faded from red to a tired pink. It was thin. Most people’s were.

“There he is,” Pop said. “Sixteen. How’s it feel?”

“Same as fifteen.”

“Give it till lunch.” Pop slid a plate across the table: one fried egg and a bun with a candle stuck in it. “Your mother left that before her shift. Says happy birthday, says don’t be a smart mouth at the Bindery, says wear the good shirt.”

“I’m wearing the good shirt.”

Pop looked at the shirt. “That’s the good shirt?”

“It’s the one without the hole.”

Tess was still watching him over her cards. “Do you think Talia will come? To the Bindery? For your day?”

“Why would she?”

It came out flat and hard, and the kitchen went quiet. Tess blinked at him. Pop glanced over from the stove and didn’t say anything, which was worse.

Owen looked down at his egg.

“Light the candle,” Tess said after a moment, quieter. “You have to make a wish. Everyone makes a wish on Bindery day. Talia made a wish.”

Owen knew. He’d been sitting right there when she made it.

Five months ago, in this same kitchen, on Talia’s sixteenth birthday, she’d sat in the chair where Owen was sitting now, and Pop had lit a candle in a bun for her too, because her own dad worked nights and somebody had to. She’d squeezed her eyes shut and wished so hard her nose wrinkled. Afterward Owen had asked what she’d wished for, and she’d grabbed his wrist under the table and whispered it, like it was a secret between the two

of them.

*Something that gets us out of here.*

*Us, she'd said. Not me.*

Then she'd gone up the hill to the Bindery and come back the Light Grandmaster, and it turned out the wish only had room for one.

Pop reached over and snapped his fingers above the bun. The candle caught.

Owen looked at it. Everybody knew the odds. Seven Grandmaster books in the whole world, and a Grandmaster book only came free when its holder died. The old Light Grandmaster had passed away last winter, at ninety-one, in his sleep. For three months after that, every sixteen-year-old in the country had gone to the Bindery holding their breath. Then one Tuesday in the spring, a girl from Cable Street had put her hand on a blank book, and that had been that.

And now it was happening all over again. Six weeks ago, the Thunder Grandmaster, a gruff old man named Barnaby Holt, had died in his armchair during a rainstorm, which the papers all agreed was very fitting. His book was sitting blank somewhere up the hill, waiting, and every sixteen-year-old in the country was holding their breath again.

But you didn't wish for Grandmaster. You wished for something good and steady, the kind of book people could build a life on: fire for the power station, water for the canals and the fire brigade, earth for the construction crews. Or one of the hundred other kinds of books people got every day. Strength for the docks. Healing for the hospital. Sound, if you wanted to work in radio. Metal, if you wanted to work anywhere at all, because the foundries were always hiring.

What Owen wanted was harder to say out loud, even inside his own head. He didn't need Grandmaster. He just wanted something that was *his*. Something nobody could look straight through.

He blew out the candle and didn't say what he'd wished for.

"Did you wish for Thunder?" Tess demanded. "You wished for Thunder. Everyone's wishing for Thunder. You can't get it, though. Talia already got Light, and Pop says lightning doesn't strike the same street twice."

"I said that one time," said Pop.

"You said it at *dinner*."

"Eat your breakfast, Tess."

"I already ate my breakfast. I'm doing inventory."

Owen picked up his plate and took it to the sink. On his way past, Pop put a heavy hand on his shoulder and left it there a second.

"Whatever you get," Pop said, "you come straight home after and show us. You hear? Straight home."

"I hear."

"Good lad."

\* \* \*

Owen took the tram up the hill by himself.

He swung up onto the back rail without paying, like always, and stood with the wind in his face while Port Aldren rolled past: the fish markets and the cannery smokestacks, the big cranes at the harbor where the earth crews and the strength crews lifted cargo off freighters by hand, the laundry lines strung between tenements. Farther up, the city climbed the hill. The buildings got taller and cleaner there, with electric signs in the windows and motorcars shining at the curbs. At the very top, the Ministry's white towers stood with a government airship moored at the mast, its silver belly catching the morning sun.

Talia lived up there now. Somewhere in those towers she had rooms of her own, and a trainer, and a handler, and a schedule written out by the hour.

Owen didn't know which window was hers, and he told himself he didn't care.

At the corner of Market Street, the tram passed a warehouse with a poster on the side of it twenty feet tall. It was Talia, the same picture as on Tess's card: hand raised, light pouring off her fingers, her face calm and serious in a way Owen had never once seen it look in real life. Under her, in huge letters: THE LIGHT OF PORT ALDREN.

Somebody had drawn a mustache on her.



Owen looked away. He'd done it in the second month, with a stick of harbor chalk, climbing the fire escape in the dark. He'd felt good about it for about a minute. Then he'd felt stupid, and then he'd felt worse, and the rain hadn't washed it off the way he'd been counting on.

He leaned his head against the tram's cold brass pole and let himself remember the whole thing, all the way through, the way he'd been trying not to for five months. It was his birthday. He figured he was allowed.

\* \* \*

He'd skipped school to go up to the Bindery with her that day.

She'd been so nervous she'd held on to his sleeve the whole time they waited in line, and when the clerk called her name she'd let go of it one finger at a time. She'd put her hand on the cover, and for a second nothing had happened. Then the gold Light mark on the ceiling, eighty feet up, had started to *glow*, and a clean white light had poured down out of it and filled the whole hall, every corner, so bright that for a moment there were no shadows anywhere.

Everybody in the building had gone silent.

And then Talia had turned around, with light still pouring off her like water, and she'd found him in the crowd, and she'd *screamed*. Not scared. Happy. The kind of scream you do on the last day of school. She'd run straight through the velvet ropes and thrown herself at him so hard they'd both nearly gone over, and she'd been laughing and crying at the same time, her face pressed into his shoulder, saying, "*Owen, Owen, Owen, did you see, did you SEE,*" and he'd been laughing too, spinning her around in the middle of the Bindery with three hundred people staring, and he had never in his whole life been so happy for another person.

"*Us,*" she'd said into his ear. "*I told you. I told you, didn't I? Us.*"

Then the men in grey suits had come through the doors. They'd been polite about it. They'd said *Miss Reyes* and *congratulations* and *if you'd come with us, please*, and they'd walked her out to a black motorcar at the bottom of the steps. She'd leaned out of the back window as it pulled away and yelled back at him over the traffic: "*Tonight! Come over tonight! Bring cake!*"

So he had.

He'd taken every coin he'd saved from coiling rope on the docks that spring, and he'd gone down to Sorrell's bakery and bought the best cake in the window, the kind with real sugar icing, and he'd stood there while Mrs. Sorrell piped *TALIA* across the top in gold, because gold was the Light Grandmaster's color and he'd wanted it to be perfect. He'd carried it all the way back to Cable Street in both arms like it was made of glass.

There had been a black motorcar parked outside her building. There had been two men in grey suits standing by the front steps, and a third one on the landing, and the door of the Reyes flat had been open, with light spilling out of it.

Talia had been standing in the doorway.

She'd changed out of her school clothes. She was wearing something white that he'd never seen before, stiff and new, and her hair was pinned up, and there was a tall thin man in a grey suit standing at her shoulder with a wristwatch he kept looking at. Owen had come up the stairs with the cake, grinning, and said, "Tal! Look. Look what I..."

And she had looked at him.

She'd looked right at him, for one second, with an expression he'd never seen on her face before and couldn't name.

Then she'd looked away, as if he were nobody. As if he were a stranger who'd come up the wrong stairs. She'd turned to the man in the grey suit and said something too quiet to hear, and the man had nodded, and she had gone back inside, and the door of the Reyes flat had closed.

Just like that.

Owen had stood on the landing holding the cake. One of the men in grey had looked at him, and then at the cake, and then back at the door, and hadn't said anything at all. After a while Owen had gone back down the stairs. He'd sat on the front step in the dark for a long time, with the cake on his knees and *TALIA* written across it in gold, waiting for the door to open again.

It hadn't.

In the morning, the black motorcar was gone, and so was she. She'd moved up the hill that night. She hadn't said goodbye. She never wrote. She never visited. Not one letter in five months, not one word, though the tram

went up the hill every twenty minutes and she knew exactly which window on Cable Street was his, because she'd climbed through it about a thousand times.

Two months later, a signed card had come in the post for Tess.

Nothing for Owen.

He'd given the cake to the Delgado kids on the first floor. He hadn't been able to eat it. He hadn't been able to eat anything from Sorrell's since.

\* \* \*

The tram ground its way up the hill, and the Bindery came into view.

It was the biggest building Owen had ever been inside. The whole place was white marble, cold and echoing, with brass rails that split the floor into long lines and a ceiling painted with the seven Grandmaster marks in gold leaf: flame, water, air, earth, light, ice, and thunder, so high up you had to lean back to see them. The Light mark had been freshly regilded this spring, and it shone brighter than the others. Under the Thunder mark, somebody had hung a long black ribbon for mourning, and it stirred a little in the draft from the doors. Big brass electric lamps hung on long chains from the ceiling, and a clock hung on the wall behind every clerk's desk, and all of them ticked together, so the whole hall had a slow, steady pulse to it.

The line was full of sixteen-year-olds and their mothers. Owen's mother was at the cannery and his father was at the station, because you didn't miss a shift for a Bindery day unless you could afford to, and the Calders couldn't. It didn't matter. Plenty of kids came alone. He found the end of the line and stood in it.

A sign at the front said HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY in letters two feet tall. A man with a mop was leaning against the wall by the door, looking bored. Along the walls, every twenty feet or so, stood a Bindery warden in a dark grey uniform with a brass whistle on a chain and a heavy leather case on his belt. Owen had never paid them much attention before. Nobody did. They were there for the rare kid whose first touch went wrong, the fire that went up too high or the water that wouldn't stop.

It went slowly. At the front of each line was a desk, at each desk was a clerk in a green visor, and in front of each clerk was a stack of blank books: plain grey cloth, all the same. You gave your name. You put your hand on a book. And then something happened.

Owen had been to watch before, and none of it surprised him. It was the same every year. A girl two lines over put her hand down and her book went hot and smoked a little, and a red mark inked itself onto the cover, and her whole family cheered, because fire was the power station. A tall boy got water, and his book soaked through and dripped on the marble, and the man with the mop sighed and went over to it. A heavyset kid got strength and accidentally lifted the front of the desk an inch off the floor, and the clerk said *"Put it down, please,"* without even looking up. A small girl got healing, and a boy right after her got sound and said "Oh!" so loud it rattled the windows, and then clapped both hands over his mouth, horrified, while everybody laughed.

Nobody made a fuss over any of it. A book was a book. A mark was a mark. It was a good day, and a normal one.

*"Next,"* called the clerk at the front of the line. The line shuffled forward. Owen shuffled with it.

Behind him, somebody gasped. Then somebody else did. Then the whole back half of the hall went quiet, and a murmur started at the doors and rolled forward like a wave: *it's her, it's her, that's the Light Grandmaster.*

Owen didn't turn around.

He didn't have to. He could hear her coming across the marble floor, fast, the way she'd always walked, like she was late for something. He could hear a man's heavier footsteps hurrying after her, and a man's voice saying, "Miss Reyes, *please*, the schedule." He could hear people shuffling back out of her way. And then he could feel it, the way you feel sun on the back of your neck, when she stopped right behind him.

"Owen," Talia said.

He looked straight ahead at the sign. HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE READY.

"Owen. Hey." Her voice was a little out of breath. "Happy birthday. I wasn't sure if you'd... I wanted to be here. For yours."

He didn't say anything. He didn't turn around.

For five months he'd had whole arguments with her in his head, on the roof, on the tram, in the dark before he fell asleep. He'd planned exactly what he'd say to her if she ever came back. He'd had speeches. He'd won every single one of those arguments.

And now she was right here, close enough that he could feel the strange warmth coming off her like a stove, and he found he didn't want any of the speeches. He only wanted one thing. He wanted her to know what it had felt like, standing on that landing with a cake in his arms, while a door closed.

So he looked straight ahead and said nothing at all.

The hall had gone very quiet around them. Everyone was staring. The Light Grandmaster, in her long white coat with the gold mark on the shoulder, standing in a Bindery line behind a skinny dock kid in a patched shirt, and the dock kid wouldn't even turn around.

"Owen," Talia said again, much quieter. "*Please*. I know. I know what I did. There's a reason, I swear there's a reason, I just can't..."

"Miss Reyes," said the man's voice behind her, low and urgent. Owen knew that voice. He'd heard it on a landing on Cable Street, five months ago. "Twenty minutes. The airfield. And people are *watching*."

"I *know*, Mr. Crane." A pause. Then, very quietly, to the back of Owen's head: "I'm going to stay until you're done. You don't have to talk to me. I'm just going to stay."

Owen stared at the sign until the letters stopped looking like words.

"*Next*," called the clerk.

It was Owen.

\* \* \*

The clerk was a thin, tired man with a pencil behind his ear and a nameplate that said MR. PETTIBONE. He looked at Owen's certificate, looked at his ledger, wrote a number, and slid a blank book across the desk. Just grey cloth and blank pages, with a faint smell of dust and glue.

"Palm flat on the cover," Mr. Pettibone said. "Don't pull away, whatever it feels like."

Nobody was watching.

Owen realized it all at once. The whole hall was still staring at Talia: whispering, pointing, a girl two lines over trying to work up the nerve to ask for her autograph. Even Mr. Pettibone kept glancing past Owen's shoulder at the white coat. Owen was standing at the desk on his own Bindery day, the one day in your whole life when everybody is supposed to be watching you, and he was invisible. He was standing in her shadow, which was a funny thing to be able to do with somebody made of light.

Something hot and heavy went through his chest. He was ashamed of it, and it didn't go away. If anything, it got heavier.

He wiped his hand on his trousers. His heart was going hard.

He put his hand on the book.

\* \* \*

The first thing he felt was nothing at all.

The book was cool and dry under his palm, just cloth, and for one long second nothing happened, and Owen had time to think, *Of course. Of course it's nothing. Of course it's me.*

Then the weight came.

It didn't come *to* him. It came *out* of him. It poured out of the book and up his arm and through his chest, and out, out in every direction at once, like a wave rolling out from a stone dropped in still water, except the wave was *heavy*, heavier than anything, heavy the way the bottom of the harbor is heavy, heavy the way the whole world is heavy when you're lying awake at three in the morning.

Mr. Pettibone went down first. He didn't fall. He was *pressed*, face-first onto his own ledger, as if a giant hand had come down on the back of his head. His visor cracked. His pencil shot off the desk and hit the marble so hard it snapped in half.

Then the whole line behind Owen went down.

It happened all at once, three hundred people, like a field of wheat under a sudden wind. Knees buckled. Mothers folded over their children. The heavyset kid who'd lifted the desk hit the floor on his hands and knees and then his elbows gave out and he went flat. The tall boy's wet book tore out

of his hands and slammed into the floor with a *crack*. People screamed, and then they couldn't scream, because they couldn't lift their chests to breathe enough to do it. All they could do was lie there, pinned, gasping, with their cheeks pressed against the cold white marble.

The brass rails bent. Owen watched them do it: long, polished brass rails sagging slowly toward the floor in the middle, groaning, like licorice left out in the sun. The chains of the great electric lamps snapped taut, and the lamps dropped two feet all at once and hung there, swinging and straining, the bulbs flaring and popping one after another in bursts of white glass. Along the far wall, the clocks tore loose from their hooks. They didn't fall so much as get *yanked* to the floor, all of them, one after another down the whole length of the hall, *smash smash smash smash*, until there was no ticking left at all.

The marble under the desk cracked. A thin black line ran out from Owen's feet, and then another, and then a whole ring of them, spreading slowly out through the white stone like frost across a window.

Dust sifted down from the ceiling in long grey curtains. High above, eighty feet up, the seven gold Grandmaster marks trembled on the plaster.

And Owen stood in the middle of it all, and he felt *light*.

That was the worst part. That was the part he would remember afterward, in the dark, for a long time. Everyone in the building was being crushed into the floor, and he felt lighter than he had in five months. Lighter than air. As if the weight he'd been carrying around since that night on the landing had finally, *finally* gone somewhere, and he never had to hold it again.

Then he looked down.

Nobody was standing. Nobody in the whole Bindery, not the clerks, not the wardens along the walls, not the man with the mop. Everyone was down, pressed flat, three hundred people lying on the marble with their faces turned toward him, and every single one of them was staring at him.

*Everyone was watching him now.*

The thought came, and it was so ugly that it frightened him more than anything else in the room.

He tried to take his hand off the book. It wouldn't come. It was the only thing in the building that wasn't heavy, and it was stuck to the cover like it had grown there.

*"Owen."*

He turned his head.

Talia was the only one moving. She was down like everyone else, but she was fighting it. She had one hand flat on the marble and the other pressed to her chest, and light was coming off her in waves, bright white-gold light, flaring and flickering like a lamp in a gale, pushing back against the weight. Her long white coat was spread out on the floor around her. Her jaw was clenched so hard he could see the muscle standing out. Slowly, shaking, inch by inch, she was pushing herself up onto one knee.

The Light Grandmaster, on her knees in the Bindery. On her knees in front of him.

*"Owen,"* she said again, through her teeth. Her golden eyes were fixed on his face. She didn't look angry. She didn't look scared of him. She looked scared *for* him. *"Owen. Look at me. Let go. You have to let go."*

*"I can't..."*

*"Yes, you can. It's yours. It listens to you. Just let go."*

He looked at her. At her face, and her shaking arm, and the light pouring off her like it had poured off her five months ago in this same hall, when she'd run through the ropes and thrown her arms around him and said *us*.

Something in his chest let go before his hand did.

The weight *stopped*.

It didn't fade. It just stopped, all at once, the way a sound stops when you close a door. The lamps jerked back up on their chains and swung wildly, creaking. The dust hung in the air. The brass rails stayed bent. Three hundred people took one huge, ragged breath at the same time, and then the hall filled up with coughing and crying and a child somewhere wailing at the top of his lungs.

Owen's hand came off the book.

He looked down at it. A mark had inked itself onto the grey cloth while he wasn't looking, dark as a bruise, and it wasn't a flame or a wave or any of



the others from the ceiling. The book was thicker than it had been, and heavy, so heavy he could feel it pulling at the desk. Only the first page had filled. He could see a single word written at the top of it in dark ink, through the gap in the cover.

**Gravity.**

\* \* \*

Nobody moved for a moment. Then everybody moved at once, scrambling back, away from the desk, away from him, dragging their children with them, bumping into each other in their hurry. A ring of empty cracked marble opened up around him. Nobody would come inside it.

Mr. Pettibone was sitting on the floor behind the desk with his broken visor in his hands, staring at Owen like he was a lit stick of dynamite.

And then, from somewhere across the hall, someone blew a whistle.

It was a long, sharp blast, and then another answered it from the far wall, and another from the doors, and suddenly the wardens were coming. They were dusty and bruised, some of them limping, but they were coming across the cracked marble from every side at once in their dark grey uniforms, and they'd opened the heavy leather cases on their belts. Owen saw what was in them. Cuffs. Thick, dull iron cuffs, with strange marks cut into them in rings, marks that weren't in any registry he'd ever seen.

"I didn't..." Owen took a step back and hit the desk. "I didn't *mean*... I didn't do anything, it just..."

The first warden reached him. Then two more. Nobody said anything to him. Nobody said his name. They took his arms, not roughly but not gently either, and turned him around and pushed him face-first against the desk, the same desk where Mr. Pettibone had been crushed flat a minute ago. Someone yanked his hands behind his back.

The iron closed around his wrists.

It was *cold*. Not normal cold, like metal. A deep, strange cold that went straight up his arms and into his chest and found the place where the weight had come from and pressed down on it, hard, until it went quiet. He felt his book go dead on the desk in front of him, like a light going out.

A warden picked up the book with a pair of heavy gloves, the way you'd pick up something that might bite, and dropped it into an iron box and shut the lid.

"Hey!" Owen twisted around. "That's *mine!* That's..."

"Walk," said the warden holding his arm.

"Where? Where are we..."

"Walk."

They walked him. Across the cracked marble, through the ring of people pressed back against the walls, past the bent brass rails and the smashed clocks and the swinging broken lamps. Everyone stared. Everyone. A mother pulled her daughter behind her skirt as he went by. A boy he'd been standing in line with an hour ago, the one who'd gotten sound, looked at him with his mouth open and didn't make a sound at all.

At the side of the hall, near the desks, an old woman with white hair and reading glasses on a chain was pulling herself up by a clerk's chair. She wasn't looking at Owen. She was looking at the iron box in the warden's arms, and her face had gone completely white.

"Stop!"

Talia.

She was on her feet. Owen didn't know how. Her white coat was grey with dust and her hair had come half out of its ribbon, and she was still shaking, but she was on her feet and she was running across the hall toward him, and the light was coming off her again, so bright that the wardens had to squint.

"Stop! Let him go! He didn't do anything, he didn't *mean* it, it was his first touch, it happens, it happens *twice a week*, you can't just..."

Mr. Crane caught her by the arm. Owen had never seen the man move fast before. He caught her and held on, even as her light flared hot enough to make him flinch.

"Miss Reyes. *Miss Reyes*. This is not your concern."

"*Not my...*" She wrenched against his grip. "*He's my...* Let go of me!"

"You cannot be seen with this," Mr. Crane said, low and very fast. "Do you understand me? Not now. Not with *this*. Not after everything we've..."

"*I don't care!*"

The wardens kept walking. The bronze doors were open ahead, full of bright morning sunlight, and at the bottom of the steps Owen could see a long black motorcar with its back door already standing open, waiting. He stumbled on the top step, and a warden's hand hauled him upright again.

He looked back.

He couldn't help it. He looked back over his shoulder through the doors, into the wrecked white hall, and she was right there. She was still fighting against Mr. Crane's grip, still reaching for him, her hand stretched out toward him across the cracked marble with light spilling off her fingers. And her face was the face he'd seen five months ago, on a landing on Cable Street, for one second before a door closed. He still couldn't name it.

But he was starting to think it might not have been what he'd thought.

"OWEN!" Talia screamed. Her voice cracked in half. "*Where are you taking him? WHERE ARE YOU TAKING HIM?*"

Nobody answered her.

The motorcar door slammed shut.

## CHAPTER TWO

# THE LOW OFFICE

The motorcar didn't go up the hill.

Owen had been sure it would. He'd been sitting in the back seat between two wardens with his hands locked behind him, watching the bronze doors of the Bindery shrink in the rear window, and he'd been sure that any second now the car would swing left onto Crown Avenue and start the long climb toward the white towers, the same way the black motorcar had carried Talia five months ago.

Instead it turned right. Then right again. It crept along the side of the Bindery, so close that Owen could have touched the marble if his hands had been free, and then it dipped down a ramp he had never noticed in sixteen years of walking past this building. A pair of iron gates opened at the bottom without anyone getting out to open them, and the car rolled through into the dark, and the gates closed behind it.

The headlamps showed a tunnel. Old brick, black with damp, curving away downhill.

Nobody in the car said anything. The warden on Owen's left had the iron box on his knees, both gloved hands flat on the lid, the way you'd hold down something that might try to get out. The warden on his right was looking straight ahead. Neither of them had looked at Owen once since the Bindery steps.

Owen's wrists ached. The cuffs were thick and dull and heavier than they looked, and the cold coming off them hadn't let up for a second. It sat in his arms like frozen water. It sat in his chest, in the place where the weight had come from, pressing down on it the way you'd press a hand over somebody's mouth.

"What are these?" His voice came out cracked. He cleared his throat and tried again. "The cuffs. What are they?"

The warden on his right didn't turn his head. "Binders."

“What do they do?”

“They bind.”

The car rolled on. The tunnel curved, and curved again, always down.

Owen leaned his head back against the leather seat and closed his eyes and tried to breathe slowly, the way Mom had taught him when he was small and couldn't sleep through a thunderstorm. In through the nose. Out through the mouth. It didn't help. Every time he closed his eyes he saw the hall. The brass rails bending. Mr. Pettibone's face pressed into his ledger. Three hundred people flat on the marble, and all of them looking at him.

And Talia.

On her knees. Light pouring off her. *Let go. It listens to you.*

Then Talia with Mr. Crane's hand on her arm, and her voice screaming *where are you taking him.*

He'd almost believed it. For about half a second, on the steps, looking back at her face, he'd almost let himself think it meant something. But he'd had a long, dark tunnel to think it over since then, and it didn't take long to come undone.

Mr. Crane was Ministry. Mr. Crane had stood at her shoulder on that landing five months ago while she shut the door in Owen's face. Mr. Crane had been at the Bindery this morning, checking his watch, and the moment it went wrong, there had been wardens with cuffs ready in their belt cases, as if they'd been expecting it. As if somebody had told them to expect it.

She'd said she'd stay until he was done.

She'd stayed, all right. She'd stayed right up until they put him in the car.

Something moved under the cold in his chest. Something hot. The Binders around his wrists went colder in answer, so cold it burned, and Owen hissed through his teeth and made himself stop thinking about her.

The warden on the left glanced down at the cuffs. Then, for the first time, at Owen's face. Then he looked away again, and his gloved hands pressed a little harder on the lid of the box.

\* \* \*

The tunnel ended at a wall of iron.

Two more wardens were waiting there with lanterns. They opened the car door and pulled Owen out by the elbows, and the cold air hit him, wet and old, smelling of stone and rust and something underneath that he couldn't name. Something like the inside of a church that had been shut up for a hundred years.

There was a lift cage set into the iron wall. They put him in it, and three wardens got in after him, and the one with the box, and someone pulled the gate shut with a clang that went on echoing for a long time.

Then they went down.

Owen had ridden lifts before, in the big department store on Market Street where Mom took them once a year to look at the Christmas windows. This was nothing like that. The cage dropped through solid rock, lit only by the lantern swinging from the warden's hand, and it kept dropping, long past where it should have stopped. The walls went from brick to rough-cut stone to something older than that: huge smooth blocks fitted together without mortar, so tight you couldn't have slid a knife blade between them. Owen counted slowly in his head to keep from shaking. He got to ninety before the cage shuddered and stopped.

"How far down are we?"

No answer. They opened the gate and walked him out.

It was a corridor. Long and straight and low, with a line of caged electric bulbs down the middle of the ceiling that hummed and flickered. The floor was the same old smooth stone, worn into a shallow groove down the middle by more feet than Owen could imagine. Iron doors lined both walls, each one with a small slot at eye level and a number painted above it in faded white.

And on the walls between the doors, there were marks.

Or there had been. Someone had painted them there once, big and careful, one between every pair of doors, and then someone else had come along later with a chisel and scraped every single one of them off. All that was left were ghost shapes, pale gouged outlines in the stone where the paint had been, and deep angry scratches across the middle of each one.

Owen counted them as they walked. He couldn't help it.

Seven. Seven scraped-off shapes.

They stopped at a door with the number 4 above it. One warden unlocked it with a key the size of Owen's hand. Another pushed him inside.

"Wait," Owen said. "My book. That's my..."

The door shut.

He heard the key turn. He heard their footsteps going away down the corridor, and the lift gate clang, and the long mechanical groan of the cage going up, and up, and up, until he couldn't hear it anymore.

Then he couldn't hear anything at all.

\* \* \*

The cell was small. Stone walls, stone floor, stone ceiling low enough that Owen could have touched it flat-handed if his hands had been free. A narrow iron cot bolted to the wall with a thin grey blanket folded on it. A bucket in the corner. A single electric bulb in a wire cage above the door, giving off a thin yellow light that didn't quite reach the corners.

That was all.

He stood in the middle of it for a long time, because he didn't know what else to do.

Then he sat down on the edge of the cot, awkwardly, with his hands still locked behind him, and stared at the iron door.

*Whatever you get, you come straight home after and show us. Straight home.*

Pop would be at the station now. He'd be shoveling coal into the boilers, snapping his little flame, thinking about what book his son had gotten. Mom would be at the cannery. Tess would be at school, telling everyone in her class that her brother was getting his griamore today, and making them all guess what it would be.

They'd come home at six. They'd sit down at the kitchen table with the bun from breakfast still on the counter. And they'd wait.

And Owen wouldn't come.

Would anybody tell them? Would a man in a grey suit knock on the door on Cable Street and take his hat off and say *there's been an accident*? Or would nobody come at all, and they'd just keep waiting, Tess falling asleep on the couch with her cards, Pop sitting up by the window, Mom pretending to read, all night, and the next night, and the next?

He didn't know which would be worse.

He found that his face was wet. He couldn't wipe it. He sat on the cot with his hands locked behind his back and let it run, because there was no one to see, and then he was angry at himself for it, and then he was angry at everything, at the wardens and the Binders and the Ministry and Talia, *Talia*, who was up the hill right now in her tower with her white coat and her handler, and who had stood and watched while they did this to him.

The cold in the cuffs bit down. He gasped and bent double over his knees until it passed.

The bulb over the door flickered.

Owen looked up. It flickered again, a quick dimming, like someone passing in front of it. Then it was steady.

In the far corner of the cell, where the light didn't quite reach, the shadow looked deeper than it should have been.

He stared at it. It was just a corner. Just a shadow.

Some time later, he didn't know how long, the key turned.

Owen sat up so fast he nearly fell off the cot. But it wasn't anyone new. It was the warden from the motorcar, the one who'd held the iron box on his knees. Up close, in the yellow light, he was older than Owen had thought, with grey in his moustache and a face like a folded map. He had a tin cup in one hand.

He didn't say anything. He came over and held the cup to Owen's mouth, the way you'd help a small child, because Owen's hands were still locked behind him. It was water, cold and tasting of iron. Owen drank all of it. He hadn't known how thirsty he was.

The warden straightened up. He looked at the Binders on Owen's wrists, and then, for a long moment, at the dark corner of the cell. Something moved in his face.

"Listen to me, son," he said, very low, so that it wouldn't carry to the corridor. "Tonight, if the light goes out, you keep your eyes shut. You hear?"

Owen stared at him. "Why? What's..."

"And if anything talks to you," the warden said, "don't talk back. Don't you give it a single word. Not even *no*." He glanced at the corner again.



"The last boy in this cell talked back."

"What happened to him?"

The warden didn't answer. He took the empty cup and went out, and the key turned behind him, and Owen was alone with the corner again.

He was very tired. He'd been up since dawn. He'd crushed three hundred people into a marble floor. He lay down on his side on the cot, the only way he could with his arms locked behind him, and pulled his knees up, and kept his eyes on the corner until they closed on their own.

\* \* \*

He woke to the sound of the key.

The door swung open, and a young man walked in, eating an apple.

He couldn't have been more than twenty-three. He was slim and pale, with neat dark hair combed flat and a pair of round wire spectacles, and he wore a grey suit so well cut it made Mr. Crane's look like a sack. There was a small silver pin on his lapel in the shape of a closed eye. He carried a thin brown folder under one arm. Behind him came a warden with a wooden chair, and another with the iron box.

"Don't get up," the young man said, around a mouthful of apple. "Well. You can't really, can you. Sorry about the irons. Regulations."

The warden set down the chair facing the cot. The other set the iron box on the floor beside it, and both of them went out and stood in the corridor, leaving the door open. The young man sat down, crossed his legs, and took another bite of his apple, and looked at Owen for a while with bright, interested eyes, the way Tess looked at a new trading card.

"Owen Calder," he said. "Sixteen as of this morning. Cable Street. Father's a stoker at Eastside, mother packs sardines, one little sister. Ten. Collects Grandmaster cards." He smiled. "I've read your file. It's not very long. It was about a paragraph until eleven o'clock this morning. It's a good deal longer now."

Owen pushed himself up to sitting, which took some doing. "Who are you?"

"Ansel Vey."

"Where am I?"

"The Low Office." Vey gestured around with the apple, at the stone walls and the bulb and the bucket. "Officially, it doesn't exist, and neither do I, and neither, as of about four hours ago, do you. But I find it's easier to talk to people if you give them some names, so there. Ansel Vey. The Low Office. You're in cell four." He took another bite. "Any other questions before I start? I'd get them in now. Once I start, I'm told I'm hard to stop."

"My family," Owen said. "Do they know where I am?"

"No."

"Are you going to tell them?"

"That," said Vey, "depends entirely on how the next hour goes." He said it pleasantly, the way you'd tell someone the tram was running late. "Anything else?"

Owen stared at him. His mouth had gone dry.

"Talía," he heard himself say. "Talía Reyes. Did she... Does she know about this place?"

Something flickered behind Vey's spectacles. Amusement, maybe. He looked at Owen for a moment longer than he needed to.

"Miss Reyes," he said, "has been very useful to us."

He let that sit in the air. Owen felt it land in his chest like a stone.

*Useful.*

"Right," said Vey brightly, and set the apple core on his knee. "Let's begin with a story. Stop me if you've heard it. You haven't. Nobody has, that's rather the point."

\* \* \*

"You know about the seven Grandmasters," Vey said. "Everyone does. Flame, water, air, earth, light, ice, thunder. Seven great books, handed down from one holder to the next, painted in gold on the Bindery ceiling right over your head. Very inspiring. Very good for trading cards.

"What nobody knows is that there used to be fourteen marks on that ceiling.

"Seven gold. And seven dark.

"The dark ones were the other books. Time. Space. Gravity. Mind. Energy. Soul. They're older than the Grandmaster books. Some people who

study these things think the Grandmaster books were only made *because* of them, to have something to hold them back with. Nobody alive knows for certain. We made quite sure of that.”

“We?”

“The Ministry. The country. All of us.” Vey waved a hand. “About a hundred and twenty years ago, the six holders of the dark books went to war with one another. You may have wondered why there’s a stretch of the eastern coastline where nothing grows and the maps just say *Waste*. Or why the old capital is a lake now. That was them. Six people, and the country nearly didn’t survive it.

“So when it was over, we decided to forget. Officially. We painted over the ceiling. We burned the books that mentioned them. We took the dark marks out of every registry and every schoolbook and every prayer. We scraped them off the walls.” He nodded toward the corridor, at the gouged shapes between the doors. “It took about forty years, and it worked. Your grandparents never heard of them. Your parents never heard of them. You’d never heard of them until this morning, and you still haven’t, really, because nobody’s told you anything. Until me.”

Owen’s voice came out very small. “And my book is one of them.”

“Your book,” said Vey, “is Gravity.”

He leaned down and unlocked the iron box with a small key from his waistcoat pocket, and lifted the lid.

Owen’s book lay inside. Plain grey cloth. The dark mark on the cover. It looked smaller in here, somehow, and very ordinary, like any book you could find on any shelf. But the moment the lid came up, Owen felt it. A tug in his chest, deep under the cold of the Binders. Faint and far away, the way you feel a boat pulling on its rope when you’re standing on the dock.

The book felt it too. He was sure of that. It lay very still in its box, the way a dog lies still when it hears its name.

“Here’s the part they don’t put on trading cards,” Vey went on. “Each of the six dark books has something in it. We call them demons, because that’s the oldest word for them, and because nobody’s thought of a better one. Each demon is tied to a sin. Each one wants something, and each one gets a little of what it wants from whoever carries its book.” He ticked them off

on his fingers without looking, the way you'd recite a times table. "Time is Sloth, and its demon is called Sollumbre. Space is Greed: Karvesh. Mind is Envy: Visselth. Energy is Pride: Auranth. Soul is Lust: Lirrevain.

"And Gravity," he said, "is Gluttony. The hunger. Your demon is called Mawrenne."

He pronounced it carefully, the way you'd say the name of something you didn't want to hear you.

Owen looked at the book in the box. "It's... in there?"

"In there, and in you, a little, from this morning on. Don't worry. It'll be quiet for a while. They usually are, at first." Vey paused. "Tell me. When you had your hand on that book, and the whole hall was on the floor, how did you feel?"

Owen didn't answer.

"Light," Vey said softly. "You felt light. Didn't you? And just for a second, you liked it. Everybody looking at you. For once."

Owen's face went hot. He looked at the floor.

"That's Mawrenne," said Vey. "That's how it starts. It's hungry, and it'll teach you to be hungry too. For weight, for space, for attention. It'll never be full. Keep that in mind." He smiled. "Anyway. That's six."

"You said seven," said Owen. "Fourteen marks. Seven dark ones."

"I did, didn't I." Vey looked pleased, like a teacher whose student had finally asked the right question. "Well spotted.

"There are six dark books. Six holders. But there's one more book, and it doesn't have a holder of its own. It has to be *earned*." He leaned forward on the chair, elbows on his knees. "It's called Reqrium. It means *all of them*. It holds the power of every other book, the six dark ones and the seven gold ones too, all at once, in one pair of hands. Its sin is Wrath.

"Here's how it works. The six dark books wake up, one by one, and pick their holders. Nobody chooses them. The books do the choosing. Then the six holders start to fill their books, page by page. When one of them fills every page, *every single page*, they can claim Reqrium. They become it. And the book they leave behind goes looking for someone new, so there are always six waiting, and one on top."

"How do the pages fill?"

“Three ways.” Vey held up three fingers. “Use: every time you push your power further than you’ve pushed it before, you earn a page. Feeling: grief, rage, fear, love, anything big enough to crack you open. And fighting, especially fighting the others. Nothing fills a dark book faster than beating another dark book.” He let his hand drop. “The last time someone claimed Reqrium, the old capital ended up at the bottom of a lake. So you can see why we take an interest.”

Owen’s mouth was dry as paper. “And the Reqrium book. Where is it now?”

Vey pointed over his shoulder, down the corridor, with the apple core.

“Two doors down,” he said. “Cell six. It’s been down here for sixty-one years, ever since its last holder died. Don’t worry. It can’t reach you through the walls.” He smiled. “Probably.”

\* \* \*

“Now,” said Vey. “Here’s the part you’re not going to like.”

He opened the brown folder on his knee, glanced at something inside, and closed it again.

“When one of the dark books wakes up,” he said, “it almost always wakes up here. At the Bindery. On somebody’s sixteenth birthday, with their hand flat on a blank book, exactly like yours did. That’s why the Bindery exists, Owen. Did you ever wonder? A national office for registering everyone’s magic, in a building the size of a cathedral, with wardens on every wall? It isn’t there to give children their books. It’s a net. It’s there to catch the dark ones the moment they wake.”

He paused.

“And when we catch one,” he said, “we bring them down here, and we kill them. Before the book can start to fill. Quietly. Quickly. It doesn’t hurt, if it helps you to know that. We’re very good at it. We’ve been doing it for a hundred and twenty years. The book goes back to sleep for a while, and wakes up in someone else a generation later, and we do it again.”

The cell was completely silent. Owen could hear his own heartbeat. He could hear the bulb hum.

"That's what we'd normally do with you," Vey said. "Today. This afternoon. The paperwork's already filled out."

He opened the folder and turned it around on his knee so Owen could see.

It was a single typed page on thick cream paper, with the closed-eye seal stamped at the top in grey ink. It looked exactly like every other Ministry form Owen had ever seen: the ones Mom filled out for the ration office, the ones Pop signed at the station every quarter. Neat boxes. Neat typed lines.

HOLDER: *Owen Calder*. AGE: *16*. ADDRESS: *41 Cable Street, 3rd floor*. BOOK: *Gravity (Mawrenne)*. DISPOSITION: and then a long empty line, and at the very bottom, beside a small printed X, another empty line for a signature.

Somebody had typed his address. Somebody had sat at a desk this morning and typed *41 Cable Street, 3rd floor* onto the same form they used to kill people.

"I'd just have to sign it," Vey said, and turned the folder back around.

"Then why..." Owen's voice cracked in half. He tried again. "Then why haven't you?"

"Because this time is different." For the first time, Vey's face lost its brightness. He looked, for a moment, almost his age. Almost tired. "For a hundred and twenty years, the dark books have woken up one at a time. A generation apart. One here, one there. Easy to catch. Easy to manage.

"This year, all six have woken up. In eleven months."

He let that land.

"You're the sixth, Owen. The last one. The other five are already out there. Some of them we caught and lost. Some of them never came near a Bindery at all. One of them is somewhere we can't follow, and one of them has already killed the wardens we sent to bring them in. And every day, all five of them are filling their books.

"Somebody is going to claim Requium. Soon. Probably within a year. We can't stop that anymore. All we can decide is *who*."

He leaned back in the chair.

"So the Low Office would like it to be somebody we're holding."

It took Owen a long moment to understand. When he did, it went through him like the cold from the Binders.

"You want *me* to..."

"Fill your book," Vey said. "Every page. Before any of the other five fill theirs. We'll train you. We'll feed you, house you, teach you, and when the time comes, we'll point you at the others. And when you've filled the last page, you walk into cell six, and you pick up Reqrium, and you become it. For us. Instead of for them."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I sign the paper." Vey said it gently. "This afternoon."

"And if I say yes, and I'm too slow? If one of the others gets there first?"

"Then you'll be the wrong person holding a dark book at the end of the world, and we'll sign the paper then." Vey spread his hands. "I won't insult you by pretending otherwise. You're not a prisoner, Owen, and you're not a guest. You're a horse. You're the fastest horse we've got, and we're betting the whole country on you, and if you stop running, we'll shoot you. I think it's better for both of us if you know that from the start."

He stood up. He tucked the folder under his arm and dropped the apple core into Owen's bucket.

"I'll give you until morning," he said. "Think it over. I'll leave your book with you. You can't open it with the Binders on, but I find people make better decisions when they can see what they're deciding about."

He knocked twice on the doorframe, and the wardens came in for the chair.

At the door, Vey paused and looked back.

"Oh, and Owen? Your family." His voice was perfectly pleasant again. "Right now, they've heard there was an accident at the Bindery. A gas main. Nobody seriously hurt. Unfortunately, one boy is still unaccounted for. Tomorrow morning, depending on your answer, they'll hear either that you've been found safe and taken on as a special scholarship student at a Ministry academy..." He smiled. "Or they'll hear something else."

The door closed. The key turned.

The iron box sat open on the floor in front of the cot, with the book lying inside it.

\* \* \*

He didn't know how long he sat there.

There was no window and no clock, only the bulb. He sat on the edge of the cot with his hands locked behind him and stared at the book in the box, and the book lay still, and he thought about everything Vey had said until the words stopped making sense and were just noise.

*Kill them. Before the book can start to fill.*

*Miss Reyes has been very useful to us.*

*You're a horse.*

He thought about the old capital, which he'd learned about in school as a flood. A terrible flood, a hundred years ago, very sad. He thought about the eastern coast, where his geography teacher had said nothing grew because of the salt winds.

He thought about Talia. He couldn't stop.

*Useful.* Useful how? Useful the way Mr. Crane was useful, standing on the landing with his wristwatch? Had she known about this place when she shut the door on him? Had she known about the Binders, and the wardens, and the paper already filled out? Had she come to the Bindery this morning to watch him, because somebody told her to? *I'm going to stay until you're done.* Had she been told to stay, in case?

He didn't know. He didn't know, and there was no way to know, and the not knowing sat in his chest and burned. It burned hotter and hotter, the way a coal burns when you blow on it, until he could feel it pressing against the back of his teeth.

The bulb flickered.

Once. Twice. Then it went out.

The darkness was total. Owen couldn't see his own knees. He couldn't see the box. He sat frozen on the cot with his heart slamming, and his breath came loud in the silence, and he waited for the bulb to come back on.

It didn't.

But after a moment, he realized he could see something after all.



In the far corner of the cell, where the shadow had looked too deep this morning, there was a darker darkness. It was darker than the air around it, the way deep water is darker than shallow. It had a shape. It was tall, much too tall for the cell, so tall that it had to bend where it met the ceiling, folding over like smoke against glass. It had something like shoulders, and something like a head, bowed and turned toward him.

Where its eyes should have been, there was nothing. Just two places where the dark went deeper still.

Owen didn't scream. He wanted to. He couldn't find the air.

*"There you are,"* said the shape in the corner.

Its voice didn't come from the corner. It came from everywhere. From the stone under his feet, from the iron of the cot, from inside his own chest. It was low and slow and rough, like a heavy thing being dragged across a floor, and it sounded pleased.

*"I've been waiting,"* it said. *"Two doors down. Sixty-one years. And then this morning, I felt the whole building shake, and I thought: there. There he is."*

*"Who..."* Owen's voice was a thread. *"What are you?"*

*"You know what I am. The pretty man with the apple told you."* The shape leaned closer. It didn't move so much as grow, the dark spreading along the walls toward him. *"My name is Vorrुक. I am the fury at the bottom of every heart. I am what's left when everything else is taken. I am Wrath, and I live in the book they can't give away, and I have been so very, very bored."*

The Binders on Owen's wrists had gone so cold they felt like they were on fire. He pressed his back against the stone wall.

*"Oh, those,"* said Vorrुक, sounding amused. *"Those were made for her. The hungry one. Mawrenne."* The dark shape tilted its head at the book in the box. *"They were never made for me."*

*"What do you want?"*

*"What do I want."* Vorrुक seemed to think about it. The darkness breathed in and out along the walls. *"I want what I always want. I want to be picked up. I want to be used. I want a pair of hands to hold me and a heart to burn in. I want you, Owen Calder of Cable Street, holder of Gravity, to fill that little grey book of yours faster than any of the others and walk two doors down and take me. That's what I want. I chose you this morning. I knew the moment the*

*floor cracked.*"

"Why me?"

"Because you're angry," said Vorrुक, softly. *"You've been angry for five months. I could taste it through the stone before you even touched the book. All that weight, and nowhere to put it."*

Owen said nothing. His throat had closed.

*"She shut the door on you,"* Vorrुक said. Its voice was gentle now, almost kind, which was worse than anything. *"You stood on the landing with her name on a cake in gold, and she looked at you like a stranger, and she closed the door. And today she came to watch them take you. She stood there with her handler and her white coat, and she screamed very prettily, and she let them put you in the car. And the pretty man says she has been useful. Useful to the people who kill children in basements."*

"Stop it."

*"Five months, Owen. Not one letter. A card for your sister, to show you she remembered your address."*

"Stop."

The Binders flared. Owen doubled over with a gasp, and in the dark he felt it, under the cold, the weight in his chest rising like water in a well, heavy and hot and so *good*, and the book in the iron box twitched. He heard it. The scrape of cloth on iron. The pages stirring by themselves.

*"There,"* breathed Vorrुक. *"Do you feel that? That's a page, trying to open. That's what anger does. That's how fast you could go, if you'd only let yourself."*

Owen shut his eyes. He shut them as tight as they would go and made himself think of something else. Anything else. Tess. Tess on the landing in her nightgown, eating stolen plums. Tess doing inventory. Pop's hand on his shoulder. *Good lad.*

Slowly, the weight sank back down. The book went still. The Binders eased from burning back to only cold.

When he opened his eyes, Vorrुक was still there. It hadn't moved. If anything, it seemed more pleased than before.

*"Clever,"* it said. *"Clever boy. Hold it down. Save it up. It'll keep."*

"I'm not going to let you..."

*"Let me? I don't need you to let me anything. I only need you to be what you are."* The dark shape leaned in until it filled the whole corner, the whole wall, until there was nothing in front of Owen but the two deeper places where its eyes should have been. *"But I'll make you an offer, because I'm fond of you already. Say my name. Just once, and mean it, and I'll take those irons off your wrists. I'll take that door off its hinges. I'll take this whole building off your back, the pretty man and his apple and his paper and his wardens, and you can walk up the ramp into the sunlight and go home to your little sister by supper."*

Owen's heart was pounding so hard it hurt.

*"And the price,"* said Vorruk, *"is nothing. Nothing at all. Just a little room. Somewhere inside you, for me to sit. You'd hardly notice."*

For one long, terrible second, Owen wanted to.

He wanted to so badly he could taste the word in his mouth. *Home by supper.* Tess's face. Mom's hands on the sides of his face. The irons off. The door off its hinges. The pretty man and his paper, flat on the floor like everyone in the Bindery had been flat on the floor.

He bit down on his tongue until he tasted blood.

"No," he said.

The darkness didn't move.

"No?"

"No." He was shaking all over. "I'm not saying your name. I'm not giving you any room. Get out."

For a moment, there was nothing. Then, from everywhere at once, from the stone and the iron and the inside of his own chest, came a low, rolling sound, and it took Owen a long moment to understand that Vorruk was laughing.

"Oh," it said. *"Oh, I like you."*

*"Then do it their way. Take the pretty man's deal. Fill your book. Fight the other five. Win. Come to me the long way round, one page at a time. It makes no difference to me."* The darkness began to pull back into the corner, folding in on itself like smoke drawn up a chimney. *"You'll get here in the end. You'll just be angrier when you arrive."*

The bulb over the door flickered, and came back on.

The corner was empty. Just stone. Just a shadow, exactly as deep as it should be.

Owen sat on the cot and shook for a long time.

When the shaking finally stopped, he found he was looking at the book.

It lay in the iron box at his feet, grey and still, with its dark mark facing up at the ceiling. He'd forgotten it was there. Vorruk had filled the whole cell, and the book had just lain there under all of it, quiet, the way a dog lies quiet under a table during a thunderstorm.

Slowly, carefully, Owen stretched out one foot and nudged the edge of the box with the toe of his boot.

Nothing happened. He hadn't really expected anything. The Binders were still cold around his wrists, and Vey had said he couldn't open it with them on.

But after a moment he felt something anyway. Not a voice. Nothing like Vorruk, nothing that filled the room. It was so small he almost missed it: a faint, patient pull, low down in his stomach, like the feeling of skipping a meal. Not angry. Not cruel. Just *empty*, and waiting to be filled.

*Hungry*, Owen thought, and he wasn't sure if the word was his.

The pull didn't answer. It didn't need to. It sat there in the bottom of him, small and quiet and endless, and he understood that it would always be there now, the way the sound of the harbor had always been there on Cable Street, so constant you stopped hearing it.

*Mawrenne*, Vey had said, carefully, like the name of something you didn't want to hear you.

Owen pulled his foot back from the box. He wrapped himself in the thin grey blanket as best he could with his hands behind him, lay down facing the wall, away from the corner, and kept his eyes shut. He did not sleep until morning.

\* \* \*

The key turned early.

Ansel Vey came in without an apple this time, and without the chair. He had his brown folder under his arm and a fountain pen in his hand, uncapped, and he stood in the doorway and looked at Owen's face, and

whatever he saw there made his eyebrows go up slightly.

"Bad night?"

Owen didn't answer that. He'd spent the whole night deciding what he'd say, and now that the door was open, it was very simple.

"If I do it," he said. His voice was hoarse. "If I say yes. My family hears the scholarship story. Today."

"Within the hour. A very nice man with a very nice hat will knock on their door. Your sister will be tremendously jealous."

"And they're safe. Whatever happens to me. Nobody touches them."

Vey looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded, once, and something about the way he did it made Owen believe him.

"Nobody touches them," Vey said. "You have my word, for whatever the word of a man who doesn't exist is worth."

Owen looked down at the book in the iron box. It lay still. Waiting.

He thought about the five others, out there somewhere, filling their pages. He thought about the old capital at the bottom of a lake. He thought about the paper in Vey's folder with his name already on it. He thought about the door two down, cell six, and what was waiting in it.

He thought about the white towers at the top of the hill, and a girl in a white coat standing in one of those windows, being useful.

He thought: *I'll go up that hill one day. And when I do, I won't be waiting on the landing.*

"Then yes," Owen said. "I'll do it."

"Splendid." Vey uncapped the pen with his teeth, opened the folder against the doorframe, and signed something with a quick, neat flourish. It took him about a second. "Training starts tomorrow. Someone will bring you breakfast. Welcome to the Low Office, Mr. Calder."

He tucked the folder under his arm and turned to go.

"Oh," he said, over his shoulder. "And do try to get some sleep tonight. You look like you've seen a ghost."

The door closed. The key turned.

Owen sat alone on the iron cot in cell four, with his book lying open in its box at his feet, and the bulb humming over the door, and the Binders cold around his wrists.

Slowly, he became aware that the shadow in the far corner of the cell had grown a little deeper again.

He didn't look at it. He kept his eyes on the book.

But in the dark, very low, from somewhere under the stone, Vorruk laughed.